

Sleeper Agents: Truth, Lies, & Tropes

If you've been watching ABC's Marvel's *Agent Carter*, you have met Dottie Underwood.

She appeared as just another girl from the Midwest coming to the big city. At first, we thought she was nothing more than a fellow tenant at The Griffith, a women-only apartment complex that does not allow men above the first floor.

After taking down an armed would-be killer without so much as mussing her curls, we've learned that the sweet Dottie persona is nothing but a cover. Dottie Underwood is a Russian sleeper agent!

Marvel Sleeper Agents Playing on Our Fears

You would never expect that the sweet and boring people around you could also be highly-trained secret agent assassins. The thought that even our closest friends could be deceiving us frightens us to our core.



Ever since the Red Scare of the Cold War, the idea of a Russian sleeper agent has been the go-to trope for writers. The sleeper agent makes such a good archetype for a villain, because it capitalizes on our fears of betrayal.

Dottie Underwood is definitely not the first, nor will she be the last, sleeper agent for Marvel.

Black Widow also has a past as a deep cover Russian agent. Depending on which origin story you read, her character goes back and forth between being a sleeper agent, double agent, and so forth.

In the recent version of Black Widow on *The Avengers* and connecting movies, where Black Widow is played by the vivacious and talented Scarlett Johansson, the character acts like a mercenary. And yet, she shows loyalty to Fury, Hawkeye, and Captain America. Is this real loyalty, or is it all part of a cover? Only the movies will let us know for sure.

Truth and Flat-Out Lies about Real Sleeper Agents

Some people wonder if sleeper agents actually exist. Could that nice next-door neighbor be trained to kill? Are people living double lives to break down American democracy?

Yes, sleeper agents are real, but the reality of sleeper agents is nowhere near as interesting as the fictitious stories.

Russian Spy Ring Exposed to be Unbelievably Boring

In 2010, a network of Russian spies was uncovered operating in the United States. Anna Chapman, noted as the “Russian Spy Babe” (the red-head in the middle top row below), was one of the most infamous spies in this network.

So what exactly did these scary Russian spies do? Did they uncover major American secrets? Assassinate heads of state?

Like I said: Nothing that interesting.



Most of these spies, shown above, came to the states and lived here for 10 years before they were caught. A major part of being a sleeper agent is maintaining one's cover, which means living a regular life, so no one suspects you of doing anything else.

As they developed their regular lives, part of their mission, as far as the FBI could figure out, was to network with Americans who had power or influence over policy-making individuals or entities. In other words, these deep-cover agents were setting themselves up to be connected to people who could make things happen.

Whether they could have manipulated these people, or if they did, is not entirely clear.

Two of these spies within this network did allegedly try to recruit their son, but not in the way that Agent Carter's Dottie Underwood was recruited.

The Russian spies did not send their son off to some creepy camp for kids to be brainwashed and trained to kill their bunk-mates. Nope! Instead, the parents relied on good, old-fashioned propaganda.

These parents pushed the idea of patriotism to mother Russia onto their impressionable son. He believed the propaganda wholeheartedly. Supposedly, he agreed to become a sleeper agent.

Brainwashed Sleeper Agents Waiting for Activation —Fact or Fiction?

Another common type of sleeper agent, and a major trope as well, is the concept of the brainwashed victim being turned into a secret agent.

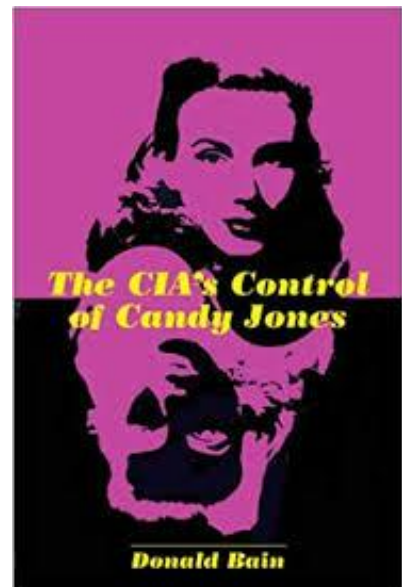
In ***The Manchurian Candidate***, for example, the main character is brainwashed into following instructions after being given a code word. Although the methods used to brainwash them in the movie were hyped up for the sake of plot, the idea of conditioning a person into becoming a spy may not be so fictional after all.

In her article, “The Story of the Real-life Salt: A Supermodel Brainwashed into Becoming a CIA Spy,” Annalee Newitz reported how during the 1940s, the CIA used hypnotism and experimental medication on Candy Jones, a supermodel and writer, to force her into developing a split personality.

When given the right activation code, (i.e., hypnotic suggestion), Jones’s conditioned alternate personality, Arlene, would take over and do whatever tasks needed to be done.

Newitz points out that all the information in her article, including some of the depictions of the depraved extremes that Arlene’s handler pushed her into doing, have yet to be confirmed by any government agency. All of these claims are based on the reports by Jones herself.

According to this article, most of the information recovered about her past and her forced split personality was discovered through regressive hypnosis treatments performed on Jones by her husband.



The Dull Reality of Sleeper Agents and Spy Craft

Yes, sleeper agents exist.

From a strategic point of view, it’s easier to get information and to influence other countries with counter intelligence if you have undercover agents infiltrating foreign organizations. But the entire aspect of building cover identities and maintaining those identities is anything but glamorous.

In her article, “Ask a Cold War Expert: How Realistic is The Americans?” Gwynne Watkins interviews Dr. John Prados, who is a senior fellow of the National Security Archive in Washington, D.C., as well as a historian of intelligence.

Dr. Prados blatantly and disappointingly declares that, “in general, spying is boring.”

Deep cover agents spend so much time trying “to remain anonymous,” according to Dr. Prados, that unless they are activated, these sleeper agents are simply not out there beating people up or killing anyone. It would risk their cover.

Then why do we see sleeper agents like Dottie Underwood ninja-bouncing off the walls and breaking people’s necks?

Because it looks awesome!

At the end of the day, Dottie Underwood is simply a work of fiction. Her story is meant to excite viewers and create further tension between the main characters. The bulk of her undercover life is never really showed onscreen, because the life of an undercover sleeper agent is, for the most part, as humdrum as any other persons’ regular life.